

BEHIND THE CANON

How the fifty were chosen

The work shown: the near misses, why each was cut, and the balance check.



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Version 1 — for Tim's line-by-line review

How these fifty were chosen

Every story had to pass four tests:

1. **Tellable.** Under four minutes, out loud, from memory, by a nervous person in a living room. 2. **Weight-bearing.** It carries real theology on its back — who God is, who Jesus is, what love does — without anyone needing to explain it. 3. **Survivable.** The meaning holds even when it's told badly. If a story falls apart without the teller getting the details right, it didn't make the list. 4. **Load-spreading.** Across the fifty, the whole gospel gets covered — no single story has to do everything, and no theme gets orphaned.

One more quiet rule: **the fifty together must keep putting Jesus at the center without a fence.** A group that spends a year inside these stories cannot drift into vague spirituality, because week after week the story hands them a person, not a concept.

ARC ONE — The Ones He Met

Ten encounters. What happens when a real person stands in front of Jesus.

This arc goes first because it's where the dechurched live: one-on-one, no crowd, no institution in the room. Every story

answers the same question — *does Jesus want people like me at this?* — ten different ways, and the answer is always yes, and never cheap.

| # | Story | Where | Why it's in | |---|-----|-----|-----| | 1 |

The fishermen leave their nets | Luke 5:1-11 | The invitation comes at work, to ordinary people, mid-failure ("we fished all night and caught nothing"). Following starts where you already are. | | 2 | **Nicodemus comes at night** | John 3:1-21 | The religious insider who has to start over. Carries "born again" back from the slogan it became to the conversation it was. | | 3 | **The woman at the well** | John 4:1-30 | The longest recorded conversation Jesus has is with a triple outsider — wrong gender, wrong ethnicity, wrong history. She becomes the first evangelist. | | 4 | **Zacchaeus** | Luke 19:1-10 | Jesus invites himself over before Zacchaeus changes anything. Inclusion first, transformation after — the order matters and this story locks it in. | | 5 | **The rich young man** | Mark 10:17-27 | The one who walks away — and Jesus lets him. Proof the table has no belief test *and* no cost hidden in fine print. "Jesus looked at him and loved him" before the hard word. | | 6 | **The woman caught in the middle** | John 8:1-11 | Religious violence versus mercy, decided in the dirt. "Neither do I condemn you" is half the gospel in six words. (See honesty note below.) | | 7 | **The mother who wouldn't quit** | Mark 7:24-30 | The only argument Jesus loses — to a Gentile woman — and he praises her for it. Wrestling with God is welcome at the table. | | 8 | **Mary, Martha, and the one thing** | Luke 10:38-42 | Presence over performance. For every exhausted person who confused busyness with faithfulness — which is most of our readers. | | 9 | **The children they tried to**

block | Mark 10:13–16 | Jesus gets angry at his own team for filtering who gets access. The household table's founding story: kids aren't an add-on. | | 10 | **The widow's two coins** | Mark 12:41–44 | Jesus measures opposite to every institution. The smallest gift is the biggest. Sets the movement's metrics for good. |

ARC TWO — The Ones He Told

Ten parables. The stories Jesus used to smuggle the kingdom past people's defenses.

Selection bias, on purpose: parables about grace, mercy, and action made it; parables that require first-century agricultural or legal context to land did not (survivability test). These ten do their work on a first hearing.

| # | Story | Where | Why it's in | |---|-----|-----|-----| | 11 | **The running father** | Luke 15:11–32 | The center of the canon. If a table tells only one story all year, it's this one. Both sons, both lostness — the rebel and the resentful religious. | | 12 | **The good Samaritan** | Luke 10:25–37 | "Who is my neighbor?" answered with the wrong hero. Action over words, love across the line — two strands of DNA in one story. | | 13 | **The lost sheep and the lost coin** | Luke 15:1–10 | God as the searcher, not the search. Told to religious people complaining about who Jesus ate with — the frame matters, keep it in the telling. | | 14 | **The sower** | Mark 4:1–20 | How the way spreads: scattered

generously, received unevenly, multiplied absurdly. The movement's growth model, told by its founder. | | 15 | **The mustard seed** | Mark 4:30–32 | Small is the design, not the apology. Every three-person table's story. | | 16 | **The two builders** | Matthew 7:24–27 | Hearing versus doing, with a storm as the exam. Closes the Sermon on the Mount and opens every Act conversation. | | 17 | **The unforgiving servant** | Matthew 18:21–35 | Grace received must become grace extended, or it curdles. The hardest story in the canon and the most needed in year three. | | 18 | **The workers in the vineyard** | Matthew 20:1–16 | Grace offends the deserving. Latecomers get full wages — essential for a movement full of people coming back after twenty years away. | | 19 | **The Pharisee and the tax collector** | Luke 18:9–14 | Two prayers, one goes home right with God — the wrong one. The belief-test allergy, told as a story by Jesus himself. | | 20 | **The sheep and the goats** | Matthew 25:31–46 | Judgment measured entirely in love done or withheld — food, water, welcome, clothes, care, visits. "Show me" is the final exam. |

ARC THREE — The Table

Ten meals. The church before it was a building was a dinner.

The most table-shaped arc of all: every story happens where a meal happens. Note the deliberate spine — it opens with a wedding, crests at the last supper, and ends with breakfast on a

beach, which means **the table survives the crucifixion**. That's the arc's quiet thesis.

| # | Story | Where | Why it's in | |---|-----|-----|-----| | 21

| **Water into wine** | John 2:1–11 | The first sign is saving a party.

Joy is not a side effect of the kingdom; it's a signature. | | 22 |

Dinner at Levi's house | Mark 2:13–17 | Jesus's reputation problem, stated by his enemies: he eats with the wrong people.

The open table is original, not our innovation. | | 23 | **The**

woman with the perfume | Luke 7:36–50 | A respectable dinner interrupted by scandalous gratitude. "Her many sins

have been forgiven — as her great love has shown." | | 24 | **The**

feeding of the five thousand | Mark 6:30–44 | The biggest table in history, built from one kid's lunch. "You give them something

to eat" — Jesus hands the miracle to the people. | | 25 | **Take the**

low seat | Luke 14:7–14 | Table manners for the kingdom: choose

the low place, invite the ones who can't repay. Guardians, not

gurus — at dinner. | | 26 | **The great banquet** | Luke 14:15–24 |

The invited make excuses, so the invitation goes to the streets.

The founding story of Door Two. | | 27 | **The towel** | John 13:1–17

| Jesus washes feet the night everything falls apart, including

Judas's. Leadership defined once, permanently, with a towel. | |

28 | **The last supper** | Luke 22:14–20 | Bread, cup, "remember

me." The table and the water belong to the people because he

gave them to the people, at a table, at night, among friends

who'd fail him by morning. | | 29 | **The road to Emmaus** | Luke

24:13–35 | Grief, a stranger, a long walk, and eyes opened in the

breaking of bread. The resurrection shows up at dinner. | | 30 |

Breakfast on the beach | John 21:1–19 | The risen Jesus cooks

for the friend who denied him, and restores him with three

questions over a fire. Failure is not the end of the story — it's where breakfast happens. |

ARC FOUR — The Power and the Mercy

Ten healings and wonders. What the power is for.

The selection principle here: never power for spectacle — every story pairs the miracle with a mercy, and half of them put Jesus in trouble with religious authorities for healing. The arc teaches, without ever saying it, that compassion outranks compliance.

| # | Story | Where | Why it's in | |---|-----|-----|-----| | 31
| **Through the roof** | Mark 2:1–12 | Four friends demolish a ceiling. Jesus sees *their* faith and heals *him* — the first story in Scripture where a community carries someone to Jesus. That's a table. | | 32 | **The withered hand on the Sabbath** | Mark 3:1–6 | Jesus heals angry — angry at religion that would rather keep a rule than restore a man. The mercy-over-rules keystone. | | 33 | **The storm** | Mark 4:35–41 | "Don't you care that we're drowning?" — the most honest prayer in the Bible, welcomed, answered. | | 34 | **Legion** | Mark 5:1–20 | The man everyone gave up on, chained outside town, ends up "sitting, clothed, in his right mind." Then Jesus sends him home to tell it — the first person sent. | | 35 | **The woman who touched his robe** | Mark 5:24–34 | Twelve years unclean, one desperate reach, and Jesus stops a crowd to call her "daughter." Nobody is healed anonymously. | | 36 | **Jairus's daughter** | Mark 5:21–24, 35–43 | Into the room of a dead child: "Don't be afraid; just believe." And then — the detail that proves it's real — "give her something to eat." | | 37 | **Walking on water** | Matthew 14:22–33 | Peter sinks.

The story keeps it. A movement that tells its failures at the founding level never has to hide them later. | | 38 | **The ten lepers** | Luke 17:11–19 | Ten healed, one returns — the Samaritan. Gratitude as the completed miracle; the outsider as the example, again. | | 39 | **Bartimaeus** | Mark 10:46–52 | The crowd shushes him; Jesus stops and asks, "What do you want me to do for you?" Dignity is the first healing. | | 40 | **Lazarus** | John 11:1–44 | "Jesus wept" — God grieving at a grave before emptying it. The canon's anchor for every funeral a table will ever hold. |

ARC FIVE — The Beginning and the End

Ten stories from the manger to the garden. The frame that holds the other forty.

This arc runs last in the list but a table can start its year anywhere; groups launching near Christmas or Easter will naturally begin here. It ends on Thomas, deliberately — the canon's final word is that doubt gets a seat and gets an answer.

| # | Story | Where | Why it's in | |---|-----|-----|-----| | 41 | **No room** | Luke 2:1–20 | God arrives poor, outdoors, announced to night-shift workers. The whole trajectory of the story, set in the first scene. | | 42 | **The baptism** | Mark 1:9–11 | "You are my son, whom I love; with you I am well pleased" — spoken *before* Jesus has done anything. Belovedness precedes performance. The water belongs to the people because Jesus got

in it with them. | | 43 | **The wilderness** | Matthew 4:1–11 | Three shortcuts refused: spectacle, power, empire. Jesus declines everything the institutional church later accepted. Read that sentence again; it's why this story is in. | | 44 | **The hometown announcement** | Luke 4:14–30 | Jesus reads his mission statement — good news to the poor, freedom for prisoners, sight for the blind — and his home congregation tries to throw him off a cliff. The way has always cost something. | | 45 | **The tables turned** | Mark 11:15–18 | Jesus's one act of physical protest, aimed at religious commerce blocking outsiders from prayer. The honest-institution story: the moment the machine met the man. | | 46 | **Gethsemane** | Mark 14:32–42 | "Take this cup from me" — Jesus not wanting to. Anguish, honesty, and surrender in one garden. Permission, forever, to pray your real prayer. | | 47 | **The cross and the thief** | Luke 23:32–43 | Entry to paradise granted to a dying criminal with no baptism, no doctrine, no time to change — just "remember me." The final belief test never administered. | | 48 | **The garden and the name** | John 20:1–18 | The first witness to the central event of history is a woman the world dismissed, and the resurrection announces itself by saying her name: "Mary." | | 49 | **Thomas** | John 20:24–29 | He demands evidence; Jesus shows up and offers his hands. No shaming, no expulsion — the community kept Thomas for the week he didn't believe. So do we. | | 50 | **"Do you love me?"** | John 21:15–19 (told with #30) | Three denials, three questions, three restorations, and one command: feed. The canon ends where the movement begins — a failed leader, forgiven at breakfast, sent to care for people. |

Note on 50: it shares a scene with 30 (breakfast on the beach) but carries different weight — 30 is a table story about restoration received; 50 is a sending story about restoration turned outward. Told two different weeks, months apart, it lands twice. If that overlap bothers you, the first alternate below slots straight in.

On the bubble — near misses, and why

These were the last cuts. Any of them can swap in; here's what each would cost and buy.

- **Palm Sunday** (Mark 11:1–11). Very tellable, sets up the final week. Cut because arc five was full and Thomas mattered more for this audience. Strongest candidate to replace #50 if the beach overlap bothers you.
- **The annunciation — Mary's yes** (Luke 1:26–38). The bravest yes in Scripture. Cut only because "No room" carries the birth and one nativity story had to hold the slot.
- **The transfiguration** (Mark 9:2–8). Fails the survivability test — told badly, it's just confusing light. Reconsider for a future "second fifty."
- **Peter's denial** (Luke 22:54–62). Partially carried by #30/#50; the courtyard scene itself is devastating and tellable. Would swap for #37 (walking on water) since both are Peter-fails stories.

- **The persistent widow** (Luke 18:1–8). Great prayer story; lost the slot to the Pharisee and tax collector, which does prayer *and* the belief-test allergy.
- **The rich man and Lazarus** (Luke 16:19–31). Powerful on wealth and neighbor-blindness, but drags the group into afterlife-mechanics debates that the canon deliberately doesn't referee.
- **The great commission** (Matthew 28:16–20). Out of scope by the arc's own rule (birth through resurrection) — but "send, don't split" is currently carried only by Legion (#34), the sower (#14), and #50. If you want the send named explicitly, this is the argument for bending the rule.

Honesty notes (publish these with the preps)

The audience we serve fact-checks. Two stories need a plain sentence of honesty shipped inside their prep, so nobody discovers it on Reddit instead of from us:

- **#6, the woman caught in the middle:** the earliest manuscripts of John don't include this story; it was preserved by the early church and added later. We tell it anyway and say so — because the church that kept it clearly knew it sounded exactly like him. One honest sentence in the prep. Hiding it would cost more than it saves.
- **#43, the wilderness:** the tellings in Matthew and Luke order the three temptations differently. Trivial, but a fact-checker

will find it; one line in the prep ("the Gospels order these differently") closes the gap.

What the fifty do together

- **The DNA, covered narratively:** the open table (22, 26, 47), action over words (16, 20, 12), send-don't-split (34, 14, 50), the water and table belonging to the people (42, 28), guardians not gurus (25, 27), small by design (15, 24), doubt and honesty welcome (7, 33, 46, 49).
- **The failure points, pre-answered:** children (9, 36), the year-three crisis (17, 31, 33), the whole life — weddings and funerals (21, 40, 29), doctrine held by story instead of statement (all fifty).
- **Balance check:** roughly a third of the stories center women; outsiders (Samaritans, Gentiles, tax collectors, lepers, criminals) are the heroes of at least twelve; children appear in three; failure by named leaders is preserved in four. That's not quota — that's the Gospels' own distribution, kept honest.
- **Fifty ≈ one year.** A table meeting weekly, with two weeks of slack for life, tells the whole gospel in twelve months — and can start again, because these stories don't run out.

Next up, per build order: each story gets full 5 Cs prep, NLT links, a told-not-read sample telling, the four table questions adapted, and an Act suggestion. That's fifty preps — the real work. This list is the blueprint; approve or mark it up first.

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